

Japan and China



MILLIONS OF PEOPLE live in crowded cities in the lowland and coastal areas of Japan and China, so there are few places left for birds to live. Some birds, such as the Okinawa rail, are close to extinction. But the mountains and forests inland remain home to many birds, especially pheasants and cranes.

The islands of Japan have been separated from mainland Asia for millions of years, and many birds have evolved into distinct Japanese species. The large variety of birds in Japan is due partly to the different habitats, but also to the climate, which ranges from warm Kyushu in the south to cold Hokkaido in the north. In China, the forests of the southwest are a refuge for birds such as Temminck's tragopan and the golden pheasant. Northern China consists of harsh deserts and grasslands, but sandgrouse and bustards survive there.

Steller's sea-eagle

The Japanese call the spectacular Steller's sea-eagle "the great eagle." Every winter, large numbers of these birds gather in the steep, wooded valleys of northeast Hokkaido. Here they are protected from the fierce winter winds at night and go out hunting for fish during the day. They swoop down to the surface of the sea to snatch fish in their powerful, curved talons. Steller's sea-eagles also feed on the carcasses of sea lions and other dead animals.



Steller's sea-eagle
(*Haliaeetus pelagicus*)
Length: 3 ft 3 in (1 m)

Chinese penduline tit

The tiny Chinese penduline tit lives in reed marshes and nests in trees, usually willows. It builds an amazing hanging nest which looks like a woolly purse. Both male and female birds weave the nest, which takes about two weeks to finish. The female lays five to ten eggs in the nest and the young birds stay in it for two to three weeks after they hatch.

Chinese penduline tit
(*Remiz consobrinus*)
Length: 5 in (12 cm)

Pointed bill for poking into bark to find insects to eat.

Japanese white-eye
(*Zosterops japonicus*)
Length: 4½ in (11.5 cm)

Japanese white-eye

This white-eye lives in Japan and mainland China. It flies from tree to tree in flocks, searching for insects, seeds, buds, and fruit. In summer, the white-eye soaks up nectar from flowers with the brushlike tip of its tongue. In winter, it often visits people's yards to feed on small insects, soft fruit, and nectar.

Male mikado pheasants have long tails.

The male has bright red patches around his eyes.

Mikado pheasant

(*Syrnaticus mikado*)
Length: male 2 ft 11 in (88 cm); female 1 ft 9 in (53 cm)

Mikado pheasant

This pheasant only lives on the island of Taiwan. It feeds on berries, seeds, leaves, and insects in dense forests of oak, juniper, pine, and bamboo. In spring, the female lays about five to ten eggs, which take nearly a month to hatch into chicks.

Mandarin duck

The Mandarin duck prefers wetland habitats surrounded by dense deciduous forest. Like some other waterfowl, this duck nests in tree holes. After hatching, the nestlings have to jump down to the ground, but their light weight and soft, fluffy plumage means they manage this feat without injury.

Mandarin duck
(*Aix galericulata*)
Length: up to 1 ft 8 in (51 cm)

The male's colorful feathers impress females during the breeding season.